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The Alliance for Continuing Education in the Health Professions' Position on Artificial Intelligence in CPD

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ABSTRACT

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence (AI) technologies has profound implications for continuing professional development (CPD) in healthcare. Recognising the need for guidance in this evolving landscape, the Alliance for Continuing Education in the Health Professions (the Alliance), a global association of CPD professionals and stakeholders who share and implement best practices across healthcare settings and professions, has developed a position statement on the ethical use of AI in CPD. This article outlines the process of creating this statement, its key principles, and the rationale behind its development. The statement, developed through a collaborative effort involving an AI task force and the Alliance board of directors, provides a framework for CPD professionals to navigate the integration of AI technologies responsibly. The position statement emphasises appropriate utilisation, privacy protection, transparency, compliance, human oversight, bias elimination, accessibility enhancement, and ongoing education about AI. As the field continues to evolve, this position statement serves as a crucial starting point for ensuring that AI's potential in healthcare education is harnessed ethically and effectively.

Use of Artificial Intelligence: Generative artificial intelligence was used in the development of this article. Claude and ChatGPT were used for general editing of the initial article draft. Napkin.ai was used to create images.

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Introduction

The field of continuing professional development (CPD) in healthcare has evolved considerably over the past few decades. The release to the general public of generative AI technologies in November 2022 has, in many ways, accelerated change. Generative AI tools offer unprecedented opportunities to innovate and enhance the planning, design, delivery, and accreditation of educational activities and personalised learning. However, these tools also present complex challenges related to ethical use, bias, reliability, and more that demand careful consideration and guidance.

In response to this changing paradigm, the Alliance for Continuing Education in the Health Professions (the Alliance) has proactively developed a position statement

on the use of AI in CPD. This article aims to introduce this position statement to the broader healthcare education community, describing the need for such guidance, and detailing the process of its development so other organisations can benefit from these efforts.

The Need for an AI Position Statement

The integration of AI into healthcare education is not a future prospect – it is a present reality. From personalised learning algorithms to automated content generation and sophisticated data analysis tools, AI is already reshaping how educational professionals work and how healthcare professionals engage with continuing education. This rapid

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adoption brings with it a host of potential benefits, including enhanced learning experiences, improved efficiency in educational design and delivery, and the ability to address individual learner needs more effectively.

However, the power of AI also carries significant risks. Issues of data privacy, algorithmic bias, the potential for misinformation, and the erosion of human oversight in critical educational processes are just a few of the concerns that have emerged. Moreover, the pace of AI development often outstrips the ability of regulatory frameworks and ethical guidelines to keep up, leaving CPD professionals in a precarious position as they navigate this new terrain.

In this context, the need for a clear position on the ethical use of AI in CPD became apparent. The Alliance, with its mission to promote best practices in CPD and empower its membership community, is uniquely positioned to provide this guidance. By developing a position statement, the Alliance aims to establish a foundation for the responsible integration of AI technologies, ensuring that the benefits of these tools could be realised while mitigating potential risks.

Development Process

The creation of the Alliance's AI position statement was a deliberate and collaborative process designed to leverage diverse expertise and perspectives from across the CPD community. The development (Figure 1) unfolded in several key stages:

- (1) **Formation of the AI Task Force:** Recognising the complexity of the issue, Alliance leadership established a dedicated AI task force. This group comprised a cross-section of CPD professionals from each member section to bring unique insights to the table. The AI Task Force is charged with guiding the Alliance in navigating the evolving landscape of Generative AI and its applications in continuing education for health-care professionals. The task force has since been granted full committee status. The committee will leverage the expertise of industry leaders, educators, and researchers to develop forward-thinking positions, create leading-edge content, and produce scholarly work focused on GenAI.
- (2) **Initial Position Drafting:** The task force began by conducting a comprehensive review of existing literature, guidelines, and best practices related to AI in education and healthcare. Drawing on this research and their collective expertise, they crafted an initial draft of the position statement.
- (3) **Refinement and Iteration:** Through a series of meetings and collaborative sessions, the task force refined the draft, ensuring that it addressed the most pressing issues facing CPD professionals in relation to AI use.
- (4) **Board Review:** The refined draft was presented to the Alliance Board of Directors for review. Board members provided valuable feedback, offering perspectives that helped to further shape, clarify and strengthen the statement.

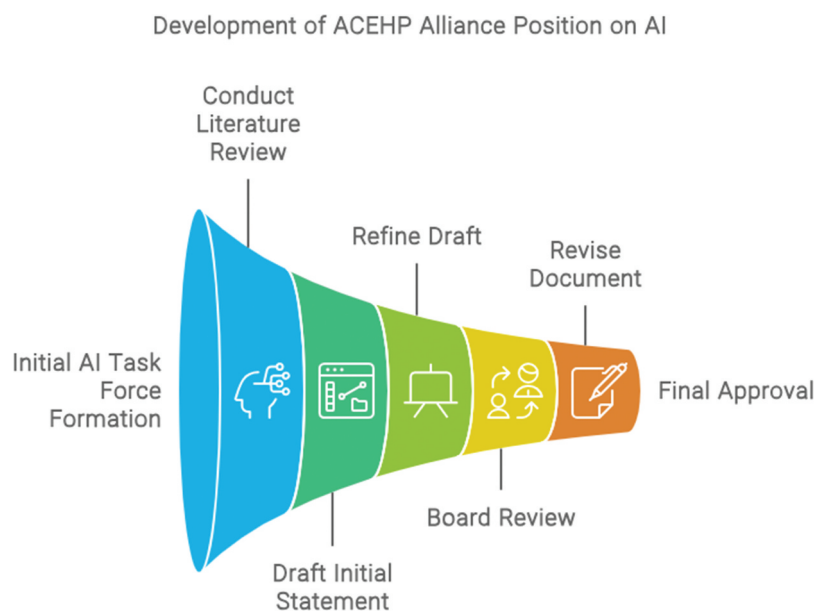


Figure 1. Position development process.

- (5) Task Force Revisions: With the Board's input, the AI task force reconvened to make necessary edits and adjustments to the document, ensuring that it aligned with the organisation's broader mission and values.
- (6) Final Approval: The revised statement was once again presented to the Board of Directors, which voted to approve it as the official Alliance position on AI in CPD.

This rigorous process ensured that the final position statement was not only comprehensive and well-considered but reflective of the diverse needs and concerns of the Alliance membership.

Key Principles of the Position Statement

The Alliance's position statement on AI in CPD is built around several core principles (Figure 2), each designed to guide CPD professionals in the ethical and effective use of AI technologies. The full statement can be found on the Alliance's website (<https://www.acehp.org/Portals/0/Docs/Alliance%20AI%20Position%20Statement%20-%20Final.pdf>). The key principles are listed below.

- Utilising AI Appropriately: Adhere to best practices and professional standards when using AI. This encompasses guidance from accrediting bodies, as well as other leaders in CPD and healthcare.
- Safeguarding Privacy and Confidentiality: Ensure the privacy and confidentiality of business, scientific, learner, and patient data when using and building AI models.
- Promoting Transparency and Disclosure: Disclose the use of AI in the creation, planning, delivery, and analysis of educational activities (creation of content, sources of data, methods used in data analysis, etc.).

- Ensuring Compliance: Comply with all relevant regulations when using AI and ensure an audit trail where mandated and appropriate.
- Prioritising Human Review and Validation: Ensure human oversight and accountability, including reviewing and verifying AI outputs for accuracy and completeness to prevent the dissemination of misinformation (the spread of false or inaccurate information produced by AI systems occurring when AI models generate content based on outdated, incorrect, biased, or misinterpreted data, either intentionally or unintentionally), errors, hallucinations (where an AI system produces information that is not grounded in its training data or factual reality, appearing plausible but are entirely fabricated or inaccurate, such as made-up statistics, nonexistent sources, or incorrect citations), and bias.
- Eliminating Bias: Implement practices that negate biases that can hinder healthcare education and perpetuate inequity.
- Enhancing Accessibility: Position AI as a tool to remove barriers to learner access (such as language translation and adaptive learning solutions).
- Educating about AI: Facilitate training and education on the role, advantages, and limitations of AI in healthcare education.

Looking Ahead

The Alliance acknowledges that this position statement is a starting point rather than a final declaration. The field of AI is evolving at a breakneck pace, and new challenges and opportunities will inevitably emerge. As such, the organisation is committed to regularly revisiting and refining this guidance to ensure its continued relevance and effectiveness.



Figure 2. Key principles.

Going forward, the Alliance's AI work plan includes:

- Educating CPD professionals on varying aspects of AI technologies in live and enduring formats by creating a curriculum focusing on AI's use in CPD and authoring articles and informational products
- Active monitoring of the generative AI landscape to proactively address new trends
- Developing governance principles, including a framework of rules, guidelines, and best practices for AI usage

Conclusion

The Alliance's position statement on AI in CPD represents a significant step forward in addressing the complex intersection of AI and healthcare

professional education. By providing clear, principled guidance, it empowers CPD professionals to use the potential of AI technologies while maintaining the highest standards of ethical practice and educational quality to improve patient health outcomes.

This position statement serves as a solid foundation, a roadmap, and a call to action. It challenges CPD professionals to embrace innovation responsibly, to remain vigilant about the ethical implications of new technologies, and to work collaboratively to ensure that AI serves to enhance, rather than compromise, the vital function of CPD.

Notes on contributor

*The opinions, or perspective expressed today do not represent the opinions or perspective of my employer.